grains with lustre loss from 10 up to 80 per cent. Less than 10 per cent will not attract the price cut.

Meanwhile, the Punjab and Haryana governments have decided to offer compensation to the farmers who have lost their crops. The surveys (*girdawari*) to assess the losses are already under way. Haryana chief minister Manohar Lal Khattar says the farmers will get the compensation in their bank accounts within three days of the procurement. Both states are using funds from the State Disaster Relief Funds (funded by the Union government) to top up their share of compensation even as the opposition parties in the states push the chief ministers to ask for more central funds from the National Disaster Relief Fund as relief. It's only after the surveys are complete that the governments will be able to ascertain the losses. This will require time, but the farmers can ill afford to wait, especially when the harvest is ready and waiting.

Meanwhile, outside the farm gates, there is politics brewing. In Punjab, the ruling Aam Aadmi Party faces bypolls for the Jalandhar Lok Sabha seat, while in Haryana, the BJP government is still trying to redeem itself before the rural farmer community. Residual anger against the party from the 2020-21 farm law protests continues to hold sway. Chief Minister Khattar is on a yatra, spending three to four nights every week in villages across the state and trying to win over the rural population before the 2024 general election. In Punjab, the rural *panthic* (religious) voters—largely farmers—are already upset and disillusioned with the Bhagwant Mann regime for the "excessive" use of power to dismantle the network of Khalistan propagandist Amritpal Singh Sandhu. The two CMs can't afford to aggravate the farmers' sentiments any further. ■



ADMINISTRATIVE APATHY
A temporary gaushala set up on industrial land in Fatehpur

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

INDUSTRY IN UP

THE LAND PANGS

By Ashish Misra

The Yogi Adityanath government's dream of converting into reality investment proposals worth Rs 35 lakh crore received at the Global Investors Summit 2023 in February faces a major hurdle—providing land for the new projects. For, it has to identify the poorly demarcated industrial pockets scattered across Uttar Pradesh, cancel the allotment of plots where no factories have come up and free them of illegal encroachments, if any.

And it's a gaushala set up on an industrial plot in Fatehpur district that has made the government wake up to this daunting task, while also turning the spotlight on cabinet minister Rakesh Sachan for alleged irregularities in the allotment of industrial plots. Curiously, not as the MSME (micro, small and medium enterprises) minister in the present BJP regime, but as the Samajwadi Party MP from Fatehpur in May 2012, when 72 industrial plots were allotted to his two educational institutes in the district.

Everything seemed hunky-dory earlier this year until the Laghu Udyog Bharati (LUB)—an all-India organisation of small industries affiliated to the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS)—decided to pitch in with the Yogi government's preparations for the investors' summit. On January 5, Satyendra Singh Patel, the Fatehpur district president of the organisation, formed teams to take stock of eight industrial areas in the district. Ten days later, when Patel reached the Chakhata mini industrial area in Bindki, he was surprised to find a temporary gaushala, housing 370 stray cows, set up on an industrial plot.

On making enquiries, he found that 32 plots, including the one with the cow shelter (established by the district administration five years ago), are registered in the name of Sachan's institutes. Two days later, another LUB team found 40 plots allotted to Sachan's institutes at the Sudhwapur Pauli mini industrial area in Airaya. Not a single industrial unit had come up on any of these plots. And not a single penny had been paid to the government to date.

Alarmed over the irregularities, Patel on February 11 submitted a detailed report to the directorate of industries, Kanpur. A probe followed, and, on February 21, the district's